# WISDOM FOR
# LIVING



DAVIDS OLUWASEYE

# WISDOM FOR LIVING

OTHER BOOKS IN THIS SERIES

*The Life Assignment*

*Times and Seasons*

*31 Wisdom Keys*

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# *Dedication*

**For in Him I live, and move, and have my being (Acts 17:28). This Book is dedicated to God is the Giver of Wisdom.**

# *Acknowledgement*

**This book is not just written, it was taught and lived. I had the privilege of mentoring an exceptional team of young men and women over different times on certain onsite and online platforms. It is relevant parts of the content taught over the years at these platforms that were worked into the books, of which this is one. I want to appreciate these uncommon proteges and everyone at the Wisdom Place, House of Insights, and other mentoring platforms, most of whom were the first set of people I shared the insights that are harvested into the pages of this book.**

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**I appreciate God the Father for His Love. Jesus the Son for His Grace and the Lord Holy Spirit for His Fellowship.**

**Davids Oluwaseye Ayodele**

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# Preface

In the journey of success, the adventures and experiences along the path are as vital, if not more vital, than arrival at the destination. Thus, in the quest for success, the attributes and attitudes one develops and what one becomes due to the demands of the journey are more profound, lasting and beneficial than the things one acquires for getting to the destination.

Like all journeys to the unknown, the value of a tour guide in the journey of success is untold. Wisdom is a principal guide in the journey of life. At every point, it tells what to do, which way to go, where to take a bend, when to halt, whom to walk with and many other crucial decisions in the course of the journey. Wisdom prevents from errors thereby increasing one's chances of safe arrival to destiny.

The Wisdom of God is the foundation upon which the entire universe runs. Access to Divine Wisdom is like having the architect who designed the plans of a very complex mansion showing one around the building. One can not miss the way when the person who designed the blueprint is the one showing the way.

This book focuses on Wisdom, especially as it relates to making a success out of your life, vision and destiny. The principles are simple and profound. They are based on the God's word. The principles communicated in this book will serve different purposes to different categories of people. Some principles communicated are things you already are aware of, this book will serve to strengthen your conviction. Some are things you need to see from another perspective, they will correct your opinions. Some are things you are already practicing, thereby explaining your results.

Whichever way this book comes across to you, you will be encouraged, challenged, inspired and enlightened.

CHAPTER 1

# THE WISDOM OF IDEAS

**When one prays for a harvest, God gives a seed. What one does with the seed determines whether the harvest will ever be received or not. Merely understanding this simple but profound truth makes one understand that God has answered many of the prayers people prayed but they did not recognize the answers when they came. This justifies God from human predicaments and places the onus of man's limiting experiences on him. God gives every one a seed but the responsibility of what each one does with his/her seeds lies them. Do you despise your seeds? Do you neglect, discard, destroy, bury, eat or expose them to predators? Do you plant and nurture your seeds?**

**Ideas are major seeds for success. Ideas are like embryos, conceived in the womb of the mind, which when fully gestated, are delivered as Success in real-life. Conceiving, developing and executing ideas is one major distinguishing factor between successful people and failures. Imagine how successful and high impact your life would have been right now if you had successfully executed all the wonderful ideas that ever flickered through your mind. Are you not guilty of non-execution of having aborted a thousand unborn 'Success-Children'?**

In Matthew 13:31, Jesus told a parable, **"*The Kingdom of Heaven is like a mustard seed planted in a field. It is the smallest all seeds, but it becomes the largest of garden plants; it grows into a tree, and birds come and make nests in its branches.*"** (NLT).

Seeds become trees and then birds find home and nest on the tree. Ideas are intangible seeds but when 'planted', they become mighty trees. The full potential of the idea in your mind is that many other people will begin to find solace in the tangible structure that the idea will produce. Your idea may be the next 'tree' where numerous unemployed people will find a 'nest'. Your idea has the capability to accommodate and bless multitudes when you 'plant' it. It is a kingdom principle that if you can execute your idea, however small it may be, it will gradually grow so big that other people can be accommodated in it.

Prov. 10:22 says, ***"The blessing of the Lord makes one rich..."*** (NKJV). God's blessing is the source of riches, wealth and success. This shows that the blessing is not money and riches but has the ability to produce them. Money and riches are tangible while the blessing is intangible. The blessing of God, among many other spiritual equivalents, comes in the form of concepts, insights, ideas, skills, graces and abilities that God endows a man with to employ for success. Insights, concepts and ideas are blessings from the spiritual realm.

A lot of people have been taught to give offerings and tithes so as to reap financial harvests. However, many have not been well-taught to recognize the harvest when it comes. One may give money and God doesn't necessarily reward them with a harvest of cash but with an idea and ability. It is the person's job to convert those endowments into money. Therefore, when God wants to make a person successful, He gives him an idea, insight, concept, vision or an instruction - all these come as intangible ideas.

## The power of one Idea

The successful people of today are those who relentlessly pursued their ideas of yesterday. The successful people of tomorrow are those who are executing their ideas of today.

You might have wasted your ideas in past years but do not live in regrets, decide to discipline yourselves to gainfully employ the ideas of today. The good thing is that you do not need a multitude of ideas to become great. One divine idea, acted upon and maximized, is sufficient to change one's life forever.

In human biology, millions of sperms are released at ejaculation, the first to make it to ovum fertilizes it while the rest die. The one in a million sperm that made it grows to become a living being who later manufactures jet engines, designs complex computer systems, builds skyscrapers and oversees multinational conglomerates. The greatness of human life is not in the million that died but the one that made it. Similarly, no matter how many ideas were conceived and aborted in the womb of your mind, there is still sufficient space and time for success in the one idea that you will conceive and execute now irrespective of the past. You can still be a success as long as you have not become barren of ideas and you make a new resolution to follow through on your ideas.

## Ideas are as Real as Cash

Idea is capital. You are really poor if you have no ideas. An idea is potential money, greatness and success. In the mental and spiritual realms, ideas are as concrete and tangible as brick. The Biblical account of the Great Flood that happened thousands of years ago showed that God destroyed the earth, not only because of human evil actions but the evil ideas. People's ideas are as important as their actions in determining the direction of their destinies. In Gen 6:5 we see that God decided to destroy the earth with a flood because the ***Lord saw that the wickedness of man was great in the earth, and that every imagination and intention of all human thinking was only evil continually.*** (AMP).

**In other words, God was as concerned about the wickedness of human actions as He was with the wickedness of their thoughts and intentions. The evil of their actions were worrisome but God knew that a higher threshold of evil was imminent when He examined their ideas. Thus, one could accurately predict people's future if one could peep into the kinds of ideas they nurture in their minds. Choose to fill your mind with ideas of wealth, greatness, success and increase. It is time for you to consider, respect, protect, nurture, manage and care for your ideas as you would do to your most prized tangible possessions.**

**In Gen 11:3-7, the people on the earth conceived an idea to build a tower in defiance to God. The Bible then records, *but the Lord came down to see the city and the tower which the sons of men had built.* We know for certainty that the building had not been physically completed as at the time of this scriptural verse because the story proceeded to tell how God stopped them from completing the project. However, the Bible says that *'God came down to see the city and the tower which the sons of men had built'*. An unfinished project was referenced in the past participle because, as far as God was concerned, the tower was as good as built the moment the idea was conceived nurtured and acted upon!**

**God attacked the project at the idea stage because He knew if He didn't stop them, they would achieve in the physical realm the idea that had conceived in the mental realm. God stopped them by confusing their language so they will not be able to communicate and further develop their idea. He did not send hail, fire or a battalion of warring angles to fight them, He simply attacked their ability to communicate ideas. Idea and strategy battles are more potent than the physical physical warfare. People win or lose in the realm of ideas.**

## Ideas Rule

Ideas are more real than cash. Ideas are more concrete than block! Ideas are potent than weapons. The realm of the spirit respect ideas. God understands the power of ideas and satan does too. This is the reason satan is keen on fighting your success and prosperity by attacking them at the idea stage.

If God gives you an idea worth a billion dollars then He reckons Himself to have given one billion dollars. This shows your prayer to become a billionaire was answered by God long ago, you only need to place a higher premium on your ideas. You need to value, respect and believe in them. Don't take them for granted.

It is amazing that we take an inventory of our lives, we take stock of our real estate, cars, gadgets, clothing, certificates and material possession as our esteemed assets while forgetting to reckon our most valuable assets - our ideas and our inherent abilities.

Ideas rule the world. Every great thing started as an idea. Therefore, in the school of success, you must master the course of birthing your ideas to reality. The following are what to do with ideas for them to become tangible structures that will reward you.

## Steps From Ideas to Reality

Great people are those who follow through on ideas to the reality stage. The following are steps to take in translating ideas to reality.

- **Conceive the Ideas:** You must master the art of conceiving ideas. Solitude is an art of royalty; when it comes to conception and gestating ideas. Meditation and observation are instruments for generating ideas. Divine ideas come as revelation into spirit.

- **Write the Ideas:** Writing is a royal behavior. If it is said that readers are leaders, then what should be said of the ones that write what is read. Writers are the leaders and influencers of leaders. Writing is a divine attribute. God instructed many men in the Bible to write down what they see. (Ex. 17: 14, Jer. 36: 2, Hab. 2:2, Rev. 1: 19). Ideas are worth so little unless they are caught on paper and ink. Very powerful ideas could be so fleeting that if not timely captured, they will pass away with all the great benefit inherent in them. Have an ideas room where you meditate, have an ideas book where you write down your ideas.

- **Develop the Ideas:** Idea development starts with the writing phase, as writing forces one to think constructively and articulately. However, writing is not all there is to idea development. Research, consultation and analysis are part of developing ideas. There is need to study cases of successful executions of related ideas, share the ideas with positive minded individual and organize vision-casting and brain-storming sessions, pitch your ideas to stakeholders. Do you now see why people usually do not pursue their ideas, developing an idea is already tedious enough a job, how much more the strenuous work of execution.

- **Execute the Ideas:** The test of strength of character is in execution of ideas. No matter how great an idea is, when unexecuted, it is as good as dead. A living dog is said to be better than a dead lion. An executed average idea is better than an unexecuted great idea. The proof of readiness for success is one's ability to take steps on one's ideas. There is always a step one can take, no matter how small for a start. An idea can be too daunting to attack immediately, but there is always something little that can be done about it immediately. It is taking the immediate small incremental steps towards the accomplishment that opens the door for the bigger

opportunities along the line of the idea. The graveyard of ideas is doing nothing. Avoid that pitfall by doing something strategic, no matter how little, about your God given ideas today.

## Exercise

1. Write down three ideas that have ever crossed your mind in the following areas of your life that you believe can change your future.
2.

Spiritual Life (I) _____

Family Life (I) _____

(ii) _____ (ii) _____

(iii) _____ (iii) _____

Finance(I) _____

Business(I) _____

(ii)_____ Enterprise(ii) _____

(iii) _____ (iii) _____

Profession/Career(I)_____

(ii) _____ (iii) _____

1. Retrieve all you past diaries, journals, ideas books, mentoring and sermon notes and take off time in a personal retreat to read through them carefully and note all the things you wrote down and never acted upon.

1. Write down one idea in each area in addition to the old ones you have written down.

Ideas rule the world. Cease praying for money, start praying for ideas and the grace to execute them!

## CHAPTER 2

# THE WISDOM OF OPPORTUNITY

**Ideas are the seeds for success, opportunities are the doorways to success. A person who has developed capacity and adequately prepared is, many times, a single opportunity away from success. Capacity building and preparation are foundational keys to success but ultimately it is opportunity that will eventually open the door. In every success equation, there is a part opportunity played.**

**Walking with God and attain success God's way is a partnership; there is a part one is to play and there is a part God will play. Bringing opportunities, many times, is God's role. Preparation, capacity building and acting on the opportunities are human role.**

**The arrival of opportunity is only beneficial to the prepared, capable and proactive. Therefore, many prayers for success were answered when God sent opportunities knocking at people's door. However, many did not recognise them, neglected them, shunned them, were not ready for them or were too lazy and laid back for them. A great skill in life is the ability to discern and capitalise on opportunities. Discernment is necessary in identifying opportunities because they come disguised many times as problems, work, questions, observation, request or a conversation.**

**A classic example of the success power of opportunities is the Bible story of Joseph, the son of Jacob, who lived in Egypt for years as a**

Slave until a single moment of opportunity after years of preparation and development of strength of character. Joseph's day of opportunity was the night he stood before the Pharaoh of Egypt and needed to interpret a dream and proffer solutions to a national problem. A good study of the story of Joseph's shows that the things he did the night he stood before Pharaoh and landed at the peak of the government of the Kingdom were the same things he had been doing for decades interpreting dreams, administering systems, developing creative solutions to problems and leading with strong character. However, he slept as a prisoner in a cell one night and woke up on the throne the next day as the ruler of the empire because he discerned and acted on opportunity. He did not just interpret Pharaoh's dreams, he proffered a solution that made him necessary and needed. According to Gen 41:33-40, he said, "And now let Pharaoh look for a discerning and wise man and put him in charge of the land of Egypt . . . the plan seemed good to Pharaoh and to all his officials. So Pharaoh asked them, "Can we find anyone like this man, one in whom is the spirit of God?" Then Pharaoh said to Joseph, "Since God has made all this known to you, there is no one so discerning and wise as you. You shall be in charge of my palace, and all my people are to submit to your orders. Only with respect to the throne will I be greater than you."

There is untold power in a single opportunity when it meets the prepared. When you have diligently prepared, faithfully made necessary inputs and consistently developed yourself for years and success is still far-fetched, then your prayer should be for God to direct the right opportunities to you.

## Opportunity Requires Promptness

Jesus said in Rev. 3: 20, ***"Look! I have been standing at the door, and I am constantly knocking. If anyone hears me calling him and opens the***

***door, I will come in and fellowship with him and he with me (TLB).*** Contextually, this scripture is a call is to all people to open the door and captialise on the opportunity of salvation that Jesus brings. However, this analogy of one staying at the door knocking and waiting to be let in applies to every form of opportunity. While Jesus waits very patiently at the door of people's heart for them to open to the opportunity of salvation, other opportunities do not wait that long at the door of life. Life changing opportunities come at a fleeting moment and it is wise to open up to opportunities as quickly as they come knocking else they would be as quickly gone as they came. The wisest approach to opportunity, however, is to go out the door and seek for them and not even wait for them to come knocking on your door.

Opportunities abound everywhere. One man's problem is another man's opportunity. Fortunes hide in opportunities. While mediocrities hope on luck, exceptional people prepare for opportunities. It is often said, *'success is a matter of luck, ask any failure.'* The truth is that *success is a matter of opportunity engaged,* ask any successful person.

The following must be done with opportunities

1. **Prepare for Opportunities:** Life was designed to reward preparation and penalise unpreparedness. The first thing to do in positioning for any form of success is preparation. Preparation entails developing character and building capacity for success, putting systems in place, acquiring necessary training, skills and certifications, developing necessary relationships as well as saving and investing financially for the day of opportunity. When you think you have prepared and opportunity has not shown up, it means you have been given more opportunity to prepare for opportunity.

Prov. 21: 31 says ***the horse is prepared for the day of battle, but the victory belongs to the Lord*** (NLT).

Preparation is not contrary to faith; in fact, the prove that you are in faith is that you are diligently preparing. The only right use of today is to use it to prepare for tomorrow. The quality of your life today is a reflection of your preparations of yesterday. The quality of your tomorrow will be a reflection of your preparation of today. A person not preparing but waiting and hoping is wasting. While waiting for opportunities, use the time actively to prepare, position, build capacity, align self and put structures in place while anticipating the door of opportunity to open.

2. **Seek Opportunities:** Another thing to do with opportunities is to seek for them. Opportunity, many times, does not just come to people, it has to be sought out. In the quest for opportunities, after adequate preparation, another vital step is to start the search. Opportunity searching is both a spiritual and a physical exertion. Therefore, in the pursuit of success, preparing, scouting as well as praying for opportunities is a necessity. Prayer, should not be limited to being a vehicle of asking for material things, it must be rightly engaged as a tool for receiving and developing intangible blessings - ideas and opportunities, among many others.

There are many wrong beliefs that prevent people from accessing life changing opportunities . Some people hold on to cliches like '*whatever will be will be'*, '*what is mine is mine, it will come to me where I am*'', '*what is mine will not go to another person but will surely come to me anyway', 'If I find it difficult to get it, then it probably is not meant for me.*

All these are half-truths that are disastrous to seeking opportunities. Opportunity will not come to you anyway. An opportunity that could have changed your life may go to another person if you do not seek it and grab it. Opportunity is in high demand, sought out by many. It does not have the time or patience to seek or wait for anyone.

If Opportunity doesn't come to you and you hear that she is somewhere, you may quickly need to go to that place to get her.

3. **Create Opportunities:** There are times when you seek opportunities and you find none, so you create opportunities for yourselves. You can create opportunities by creating a demand or need for what you can do, creating awareness of your capacities and potentials, creating new relationships and meeting people. In the story of Joseph before the Pharaoh of Egypt told earlier, Joseph actually used the opportunity to create an appointment need for himself. Quit begging people for jobs or contracts, create opportunity for yourself by identifying a problem, solving it even if you have to do it free foremost for them to see the value it will bring to them.

Men are the conveyors of opportunities and sometimes creating relationship with right people is creating opportunities. Use your talents and gifts to create opportunities by serving them out to people. Joseph created an opportunity for himself when he proffered a solution and advised they employ someone to implement it. He created a niche only He could fill.

4. **Recognise Opportunities:** One of the most important life skills is recognition and discernment. A major faculty in success is the ability to discern and recognise situations, uniqueness, opportunities, people and times. This ability, many times, does not come naturally, it has to be God given. The entrance of certain people into one's life, many times, is the coming of opportunity. However, if one does not discern and recognise the value they represent, one misses all the possibilities they bring. Situations and circumstances also bring inherent opportunities which if one does not recongise, loses out on the chances and possibilities. Truly, many look but few see. A lot of people miss opportunity because it comes disguised.

It takes wisdom and discernment to see through and recognise the opportunity inherent in people, places, events and situations.

5. **Engage Opportunities:** Finally, it is important to engage opportunities once you spot them. Engaging opportunities needs pro-activeness and promptness. Opportunity once came knocking at a man's door late in the night. The man asked who it was and opportunity replied that he came to deliver some goods. The man, in his mind, weighed the risk whether it was a thief or truly Opportunity that was knocking. So, he took some time to dig the floor of his bedroom to hide all his money and precious items and cover the floor back. He further went to get a club and machete and keep them by the door-side. He then went to turn on the burglary alarm and peeped through the hole of his window to check who it was. Can you guess who he saw? Nobody! Nobody was there. Opportunity had gone! He never had the chance to know who had visited. However, the next day, he learned that his neighbour had hit some stroke of fortune and would be relocating to a choicer property in an upper part of the city. When he asked how his neighbour could afford such expensive property, he told him about a visitor that came to him last night and brought a huge fortune.

## Exercise

- **Write down some opportunities that you had missed, squandered or wasted in the past in different areas of your life.**
- **Pray a prayer of repentance for squandering or wasting those opportunities and pray that God in his mercy will bring new opportunities for restoration.**
- **Write down three areas (limit it it to three) of your life where you most desire opportunities for success.**
- **Write three things you can do right now in each area of life to prepare and position yourself better for those opportunities if they come today.**

***Opportunities are the door ways to success. Plan, Prepare and Position yourself for Opportunities.***

CHAPTER 3

# THE WISDOM OF PRODUCTIVITY

## The Law of Value

A person is esteemed valuable when they have something of value they add to others. Your Value describes everything you have, you are, or you do that solves problems for others, puts you in useful demand and attracts a reward towards you. It is any trait, skill, ability, personality, qualification or grace that you possess that is beneficial to others and can meet their felt needs. Value can be spiritual, physical, emotional, intellectual, academic, or financial. It includes character, material possessions, gifts, skills, anointing, grace, certifications, expertise and strength of character. Simply put, value describes what you have that you can exchange for profit.

In the marketplace of life, your value creates your reward. Whenever life wants to reward with success, a need is created that one is equipped to meet. Sustainable success comes when one responds profitably to the needs which one is equipped to meet. The first question in the quest for success is, 'what value do I have to offer people'?

In 2 Kings 4, a widow met Prophet Elisha because she was in a dire

**situation. Her deceased husband left her with a huge debt and two children to fend for. The creditors came and were about to seize the children as collateral for the loan. In providing a solution to this pathetic case, Elisha directed her to the wisdom of identifying and deploying value. He asked her, "*What can I do to help you?*" Elisha asked. "*Tell me, what do you have in the house?*" 2 Kings 4:2. God's help to you will ultimately place a demand on what you have to offer. Real poverty is not having no material possession; it is having nothing to offer. People who have nothing in their hands but have something to offer will eventually have something in their hands. One will not remain poor forever who has mastered the art of offering value in a profitable way.**

**The woman in the story above made a mistake most poor folks make, she replied to the Prophet, *'I have nothing at all . . .'* However, she later realised her error and promptly corrected it by adding, *'Except a flask of olive oil.'* The really poor person is one who thinks and believes he/she have nothing to offer.**

## Sell Your Value

**The widow in the scripture used the oil she had and it supernaturally multiplied. Value multiplies when you deploy it. She exited failure into success, when the man of God instructed her to go ahead and sell the multiplied oil. According to 2 Kings 4:7, Elisha said, "*Now sell the olive oil and pay your debts, and you and your sons can live on what is left over.*" The prophet instructed her to sell the oil, meaning God is not against productivity, enterprise and profitability. Why did not God, in all his benevolence, instruct her to give the oil out for free to her hungry neighbours?**

It is because God loves and blesses enterprise and profitability. God does not have anything against you monetising your value and making financial profit out of it. God's only aversion to enterprise is when merchandise was made of spiritual things in the House of God to make money off people's sacrifices and service to God (John 2: 13 - 17).

## What you Have is the Seed for What you Want

The Biblical account of the call and commissioning of Moses also shows that God uses what you have as the seed for what you want. Your value is the seed for your success. God had appeared to Moses in the burning bush and sent him to liberate the nation of Israel in Egypt. Moses felt inadequate and wanted to know how he would succeed in such a great task despite his many deficiencies. In Exo. 4: 2, ***The Lord asked him, What is that in thine hand? And he said, A rod.*** It was the rod that God used to do miracles, signs and wonders throughout the lifetime of Moses. In our contemporary context, you may not be holding a literal shepherd's rod like Moses did but the point still remains that God will place a demand on something He has already placed within you for your success. Therefore, your personal success is in what you have, not what another person has. This is the reason, living a life of copying what others are doing is not wise. People that try to success by entirely copying others end up as a duplicate instead of an original. We succeed in life by learning from others not by copying them. Stay with God to know our individual calling and assignment. Discover and maximise your uniqueness. Focus and use what God has given you and do not be consumed about what He has given someone else. The seed of your success and greatness is inside you.

Additionally, in Matt 14: 14 - 21, when Jesus Christ wanted to feed five thousand men with many women and children, He needed to perform a miracle of multiplication. However, the miracle still started with using something someone among them had. One person presented some little pieces of bread and fish he had, God performed a miracle and multiplied them.

Even if God wants to give you a miracle, there will still be a demand on something you have or do. Waiting for a miracle without deploying value is the reason many believers have been stagnated at the same point for years. Even if you received favour from someone who gave you something free without any demand on value from your end, you should know that the person engaged his/her value to get that which you were given. One can attain sustenance through charity but nobody attains success receiving hands-out. Value and productivity is always the way to sustainable success - Ask for testimonies from the people who give the charity, not the people who receive them.

There must be something you offer as value before success comes to you. This is God's principle and he will not violate it no matter how hard the person prays. If Jesus obeyed the principle, then everyone must. Discover what you have and deploy it diligently and productively to command what you want.

Actually in life, for everyone, there is always what you have and what you do not have. You must learn to use what you have to receive what you do not have. Your success and prosperity is in what you have and not in what you do not have.

It is better to focus on what you have and not what you do not have. Failures always focus and talk about the things they do not have to the detriment of what they have.

## Intrinsic and Extrinsic Value

While people are seeking externally for someone or something to make them successful, genuine and lasting success only flows from inside out. In the quest for success, success is elusive when people seek it only externally. All profitable search for success begins internally. What will make you successful is inherent to you and is waiting to be discovered and unleashed.

Value can be intrinsic or extrinsic. Intrinsic value describes elements inherent in one's personal essence. Intrinsic value is most intangible and consists of knowledge, skills, abilities, charisma and other things that become the natural essence of the person once acquired. Extrinsic values are valuable and transactable assets that are external to one's person. For clarity, a teacher has the classroom property and accessories as external value while the teaching skills and knowledge of the subject are intrinsic value.

It is great wisdom to invest first into intrinsic value before extrinsic. To have sustainable success, it is also advisable to invest more into intrinsic value than extrinsic. Even though, extrinsic possessions are usually more glamorous and celebrated, people who understand the power of delayed gratification develop intrinsic value first. The truly successful are not in a hurry to look good, rather they are willing to build lasting success by first taking ample time to develop intrinsic capacity.

It is noteworthy that intrinsic values cannot be lost due to the risk factors that affect many extrinsic possessions. An investment in intrinsic value usually pay more dividends in the long run. Warren Buffet, a great contemporary financial investors and one of the world's wealthiest men was asked what the best investment to put one's money in. He simply replied, 'Yourself - The best investment is to invest in yourself'. Extrinsic values must definitely and eventually be acquired as one builds systems and structures around his enterprise. However, make sure that you have built intrinsic value as a foundation to spending resources to acquire extrinsic values. If one who has not developed intrinsic value, loses the external assets he has acquired, he will realize that there was no real value possessed. Certificates are extrinsic values but skill is intrinsic value. Possessions and property are extrinsic but knowledge and knowledge is intrinsic.

## The Law of Productivity

Productivity is the art of converting valuable resources into tangible, measurable and transactable output. Simply put, productivity is converting one's value to goods and services that are offered in exchange for reward. Value talks about what you have, productivity talks about what you do with what you have. Productivity, therefore, involves the dispensation of value and the creation of return channels of reward. One may be valuable but not productive; if one does not create a structure for dispensation, perpetuity, growth and reward of value.

In personal life and macro-economics, productivity is usually a measure of output based on input of resources.

Life success is primarily measured in terms of the output one generates and not the capacity one possess. There are few things more frustrating than having input but no output. Nothing more agonizing than to be knowledgeable but broke, learned but failed, capacious but mediocre. Productivity is the bridge between being full of potential and being full of results.

Productivity is the ability to create, make and enhance product and services that meet human and societal needs, it involves serving out the products and services in excellence as well as creating a medium for flow of returns to you. Productivity involves the ability to make whatever you have or do more abundant and expansive. A productive person always has profitable things to do.

When a person claims that there is no job or work, they are actually claiming that there is no value they possess that can be productively transacted for a return. When a person is fired from a job and can not find something to do to generate finances, it either that the person has developed extrinsic value more than intrinsic or that the person is valuable but has not learned the art of being productive.

## Be Productive with Your Value

It is possible to be valuable but not productive; it explains why one can be a good cook, a great writer, a fantastic speaker but still broke and jobless. Such one is valuable but not productive. Productivity is turning one's value and ideas to products and services and serving it to people and thereby creating rewards. It is not merely valuable people that become successful but productive people. Possessing value does not guarantee wealth and rewards, being productive does. There are lots of people that possess great value but are still poor and mediocre because

they camp at the realm of value. Productivity is actually the weapon for success, wealth and economic victory. Financial resources flows towards productive people, not necessarily valuable people.
Real productivity starts with a productive mindset. One of the reasons for this book is to stimulate every reader to higher horizons of productivity. Productive people are driven by multiplication and not consumption therefore they master the art of delaying gratification. Productivity-mentality are effective manager of their abilities, time and resources.

More than ever, every person, family, church, ministry, business and organisation must be determined to be productive. Failure is imminent for the non-productive person or organisation. The only way to remain productive is to be relentless in developing, deploying and adapting your value to people's current needs.

## The Principle of Reward

The ultimate measure of productivity is profitability. No matter the value one possesses or the efforts at its deployment, if one is not making profit, one will soon be out. God loves profit. In fact, God says in Isa 48:17, "***I am the Lord your God, Who teaches you to profit, Who leads you by the way you should go.*** Furthermore, Matt 25:30 says, 'cast the unprofitable servant into the outer darkness. There will be weeping and gnashing of teeth.'

God is profit oriented and wants you to be. It should, however, be noted that what describes profit to different persons and organisations differ. For example, an individual should measure profit by the fulfillment of personal purpose. A ministry or church should measure profit by souls won, lives transformed, spiritual and physical growth of

people reached and societal and national transformation. A business measures profit by money made, needs met and corporate growth. This means that when a church spends great money to win, perhaps, a few souls, it has made profit. When a charity organisation spends a huge amount of money to help a lot or a few people, it has made profit.

When a business spends a lot money and makes less than it spent, it has made a loss. It is not all profit that is monetary. Fulfillment, goodwill, joy and honour are intangible profit. However, there must be profit- either tangible or intangible, accruing to you from the deploying of your value. Don't invest your life in an unprofitable venture. Profit is the growth index in measure productivity, enterprise and success.

## Value First and Profit Later

It is important to know that most times, when one starts out honing skills and deploying value, one should not be profit driven but service driven. Therefore it is always the initial phase of value deployment when on makes the necessary sacrifices to selflessly serve out one's value even if it seems that no profit is accruing yet. This period is also profitable as that is the time one is getting recognised for one's value and sowing seeds that will be harvested with time. So, it is good to be profit oriented but one must not put profit before service. Your drive should not be merely to make profit but to serve. However, a time comes when profit becomes not just necessary but inevitable. Without profit in the long run, there is no hope of expansion, continuity or perpetuity of the value.

The concept of profitability and reward is key in value, productivity and success. In actual sense there is nothing like a non-profit venture. All venture must be for profit. The truth, however, is that not all profit are

monetarily rated. If one is valuable, diligent and productive and still struggling and losing out in life, then it is time to re-appraise one's self based on the principle of reward. Are you making adequate profit or being rewarded enough for what you do and represent? If you are doing all to be done and still failing in life, it is either that you are doing the wrong thing or doing the right thing the wrong way.

## Reward Your Value

The principle of reward and profit is important especially in productivity and enterprise. You need your value to be adequately rewarded materially or intangibly so that you will have more input to reinvest into growth, expansion and perpetuation of the value. When a value is unrewarded, it will die out eventually to loss of the owner of the value and the unrewarding users. Consumers of value who are not willing to reward it are usually the first to move on to go and look elsewhere when the dispensing of the value dries out due to lack of adequate rewards to sustain and increase the source of the value. The concept of rewards is very important in value, productivity and enterprise because anything that is unrewarded will diminish and die out. Rewards are not just the benefit of productivity, they are the perpetrators and enhancers of it.

In candid words, one of the greatest injustice you probably have been doing to your value, is that you have been under-pricing, underselling or have been giving it free for too long. This might be a reason you do not have resources to re-invest into developing it and also build a good life of success for your self. Value only multiplies when it is rewarded. If there is no reward, which could be material or intangible, value is eventually frustrated into demise. This is the reason, God is an ardent believer in rewarding people for value and inputs. According to Heb 11:6, ***He who comes to God must believe that He is, and that He is a rewarder of those who diligently seek Him.***

**What to Do with Value:**

What do you have? A gift, an ability, an endowment, an expertise, a positive character trait, a moral strength, a spiritual grace, a training proficiency or certification, a handiwork or a talent? There must be something you have. Productivity, enterprise and profitability with that value you possess is the way to success.

The following are what to do with your value:

## Discover it

No value is too little to be neglected. What you can do is a seed for your success. Talking, writing, driving, teaching, cleaning, listening, cooking . . . The list is endless. What is called self-discovery in the school of success is actually the discovery of the value you possess. Do not see what you do as small or irrelevant. View your value in a global light.

## Develop it

Many times, value in its raw form does not command the level of reward or success one desires. So, it has to be refined and developed. Education, training, studying, mentoring are tools for value development. Work diligently till you become the very best in what you do. Commitment to relentless personal development is the only ticket to world class.

## Deploy it

You must serve your value out to others. The more you add value to others, the more your value increases. Deployment of value is key to its multiplicity, growth and success. You will be shocked how big that small can become when you start taking steps. It is advisable to create or join a platform where you can dispense your value to people.

Do not wait till you attain perfection before you start adding value to people with what you do. Success is the reward of mastery but mastery is the result of practice. Practice is accompanied by mistakes. Start practicing to deploy your abilities even when it is not perfectly formed yet. However, know that tangible rewards will not come until mastery is attained. Do not be in a hurry to be rewarded for what you do, rather be in a hurry to be excellent and attain mastery in doing it.

## Reward it

After discovering and developing your value, you must take steps and launch out in productivity, no reward comes out of un-deployed value.. You must build an enterprising system around your ability and serve it out with competence and excellence. In the graph of value and productivity, there is a time when rewards may not abound yet as one is still in the learning curve. At the onset, one spends and expends money, resources and self into the value. However, a time comes necessarily when one must start having rewards and profits from the value. If you have paid the price and sacrificially sown the seed, when harvest comes, do not feel guilty or shy in receiving rewards for your value.

## Exercise/Personal Evaluation

- Take time to view your value in a broader light. List at least Five abilities/skills that you have. No value is too little to be important. Examples are driving, teaching, cleaning, listening, cooking, etc. Your gold is tied to your gift, your discovered gift.

- Write out Two Enterprise that can be built around each of the niches you have identified above.

- Write out the fullest potential of each of the five abilities/skills that you wrote above. That is, the maximum possibilities they can bring you and the peak anyone can attain in those fields.

- Write out five demands and daily disciplines that you can start imbibing now to reach the fullest potential and become a peak player in that niche.

## CHAPTER 4

# THE UNLIMITED WISDOM OF CHARACTER

In the school of leadership, greatness and success, the greatest asset one can have is a strong character. Therefore, in attaining and sustaining success, a wise area of personal investment is character development. Character is having a strong personality, moral rectitude and life disposition that is consistent with the highest values. Character is the value, virtue and fortitude to be non-compromising in the face of wrong alternatives and the ability to consistently live by highest standards even when they are not convenient.

Knowledge, understanding and application of principles are often emphasized in success, and rightly so. Truly, there are the right things to do to attain success. However, life success is eventually at the mercy of the strength of character of the person in question and not merely by the principles practiced, because nothing delivers to people beyond their character. This explains why different people seemingly do the same things and get different results. Doing everything right but being the wrong person will lead to a wrong outcome. In success, who you are is more important than what you do. Your true character is described by who you are when nobody is observing or monitoring you. Since greatness and success is essentially an overflow of one's every day personality, practices and routines; a person's character is the greatest determinant of his or her level of success.

## Can You Stand Success?

Your character determines what you will stand for and ultimately, what you will fall for. As often said, the person who stands for nothing will fall for anything. Most often, the truth about life is that it is equally, if not more, demanding to sustain success than to attain it. Absolutely, it is the character developed during the strenuous upward climb to success that sustains one when one reaches the top. Many times, the greatest gift life gives are the challenging processes on one's way towards greatness. This is because it is the traits, personality and character developed in conquering those processes and challenges that actually makes one become fit to sustain success. Most people who get to a level of success without passing through the due process of overcoming challenges on the way do not have the wisdom, strength and character to manage the demands that accompanies that level of success. Handing out success to a person as a mere act of benevolence without allowing the person to develop the requisite strength of character by walking the arduous road by themselves is counterproductive; it produces people who are not able to sustainably deliver at that level. This is the reason most people that win sums of money in lottery soon lose it all through unwise spending while people who built their wealth through nit and grit may lose all in an accidence or misfortune and still build it all back from scratch. Real wealth is not material and physical cash in possession but the wisdom, character and personality developed during the process of wealth building. Character is wealth.

## Character Development - Digging Deep Foundations

Character is the foundation for success. In building engineering, the foundation carries the entire load of the structure. Foundation are sub-structures underneath the building and are mostly invisible but they are built with great attention and strong materials as the strength of the foundation determines the fate of the entire building.

Faults in foundation may not be obvious to the observer as they are mostly hidden under the earth. However, a good builder will not compromise a fault in the foundation for anything. When there is a fault in the foundation of a building, no matter how hidden, it is only a matter of time for this fault to amplify and bring the entire building down. The taller a building rises, the more amplified the effect of a fault in the foundation is. Similarly, the more successful a person becomes, the more magnified flaws in the character becomes. Character flaw will eventually catch up and bring down success, no matter how long it takes.

The Scriptures aptly describes the fact that any admirable fruit seen on a tree is only made possible because they are unseen roots that have grown deep into the soil beneath the surface when it says, Once more a remnant of the house of Judah will take root below and bear fruit above. Success can be seen as a fruit with character as the root or as a house with character as its foundation, metaphorically speaking.

Additionally, in the sport of weight lifting, athletes are not judged only by the weight they can lift but also by how long they can stably stand under that weight. It is very possible for one to lift a load but be unable to stand under it. It is also dangerous to lift a load one can not stand under because the weight may cause one to come crashing down and incur injuries due to the crushing effect of the pressure of the load. Strong character is the required stamina to stand under the weight of success. It is dangerous to succeed to a level that one has not developed the moral strength to stand stably at.

## Reputation – The Stem of Character

One of the most important components of one's success and greatness is one's reputation. Your reputation is how people think about you and it is shown mostly by what people say about you especially behind you.

It is the emotions and perceptions that come up whenever your name is mentioned. In business, family, corporate leadership or as an organisation, your reputation goes ahead of you and determines what comes to you. Therefore, scripture says, it is important to choose a good reputation over great riches; being held in high esteem is better than silver or gold.

Reputation is an offshoot of character. The multi-billion industry of advertising and branding is all about building a reputation. However, it is known that great marketing of a substandard product is eventually damaging. Without good content, advertising will only reveal the flaws of the product to more people. The number one rule for advertising and marketing is to make sure you are good at what you do and the product will deliver on what it promises. Trying to build a reputation without character is building a mansion with a pack of cards. It will come crashing down. The best strategy to maintaining a great reputation is to consistently maintain a strong character. Character determines reputation. Reputation determines what comes to you which determines your level of success. It is good to have it at the back of your mind that everything you do and say contributes either to the building or destroying your character?

Your reputation determines whether or not people will trust you or work with you. One major thing people are looking for in all kinds of relationship is trust. Even people who are not trust-worthy are looking for someone they can trust? Therefore, everyone is looking for the person of character.

As people seek a person of character to trust, so does God. When God trusts you, He opens His treasures to you. God loves unconditionally but He doesn't trust unconditionally. He tests before He trusts. We must see every challenge we face as a test of character before men and God.

**Additionally, every time we act or speak, we reveal our character to all. A person without character has nothing no matter what he/she possesses. People with great character may seem to have nothing presently with time, however, their strength of character will produce the material equivalent of their inward greatness.**

## Trials – The Test of Character

Life doesn't trust you till it tests you. The challenges you face right now are doing one thing – testing your character. A lot of people pray, plan, work towards success but a good question is to ask yourself if you have the character to sustain the level of success you are praying for. Any man may achieve some material results through diverse means such as compromise, skill or fraternities with the powers that be – physical and spiritual powers. However, if you want success from God, God will not give you what you cannot manage and what He is not sure you will still stand for. Do you have the fortitude to be free and not be unrestrained?

Do you have the power to be high and not be proud? Do you have the power to have control over people and systems and not be selfish? Do you have the character to stand at the level of success that you have been praying for? Wisdom said, '*We can rejoice, too, when we run into problems and trials, for we know that they help us develop endurance. And endurance develops strength of character, and character strengthens our confident hope of success'*. The trials, challenges and problems you face now are to strengthen you character by revealing areas of flaws and shortcomings to be worked upon. When the test of character has been passed, you are certified ready by life for the next level.

## The Curse of Relativism

Character is the standard by which behaviour is measured. The standard of good character compels one to do the right things when one doesn't feel like, when they are unpopular or sometimes, when they

hurt. Self-imposition of high character standard is what makes a person stand for right when nobody is there to check, monitor or supervise. This lifestyle is only possible when there is an ideal that one holds to and counts as superior to one's desires, tendencies and results. In order words, a person that will refuse to do wrong when it is the most appealing, convenient and desirable thing to do is necessarily someone who has something or someone higher than himself that he sets as an ideal, holds himself accountable to and submits under the authority of. Thus, believing and honouring God is the major compass and driver for strong character and moral uprightness.

A person who believes in God accepts that there is one higher than he is, whose pleasure he must win through compliance with standards and whose displeasure as a result of breaking principles he must avoid. Since God's standard are high moral and character standards, faith and honour for God became the pillars and guard posts for morality and character since the inception of the human race. Removal of God from our societal affairs was the demise of morality and good character.

Absolutism, as a philosophical concept, believes and maintains that moral values are fixed regardless of time, place, and the people concerned. Relativism believes that the concept of right or wrong are not fixed but vary, depending on people, places, circumstances or context. Relativism judges an action in terms of reasons and explanations to determine whether it is wrong or right in that context. Absolutism judges actions by an unbending rule of right and wrong and demands people, places, circumstances and contexts to be tailored to adhere to the absolute rule. The truth is that God is an absolutist and His Word is the absolute.

One of the greatest injustice done to strong character in today's world has been the curse of relativism. Relativism makes people bend rules as long as they get desired results.

People cheat to make progress, indulge in the most convenient regardless of who suffers and satisfy self no matter who hurts. The sad thing is that they are celebrated for doing this and used as the symbols of success in the society. Relativism measures success by materialism and measures right or wrong by whether the material goods were delivered or not, the methods used is seen as inconsequential.

The decease of character was when human authorities began to bend God's absolutes and fit everything into man's relativism. The end, they say, justifies the means. Character dies out in a society when evil means are used to achieve 'good ends'. Furthermore, the 'good ends' are left to individuals to relatively define. Then every body began to define 'good end' by 'what is good for me'. Selfishness began to reign supreme and character was dethroned.

A person of character will not adopt a wrong means even if it will seemingly yield the desired end. For example, if the end justifies the means, then one can falsify details to make money even if the system would be damaged, opt out of a marriage to gain freedom even if the kids would hurt or steal to get resources to meet one's need even if the owner of the resource would be disadvantaged. Strong character demands that we stand resolute in the face of wrong alternatives and stay on God's absolute standard of character. A truly successful person is one who has mastered self and stands absolutely for the standards of character.

When these truths are said, critics are often quick to point out the people that have no value for absolute standards and character and have 'succeeded'. They also point out how some people stick to God's absolutes and have 'failed'. However, for such critics, a redefinition of the concepts of success and failure is necessary. When we get the correct definition of success, then we realize that a man without character can never truly succeed. 34

## Success from a Higher Perspective

Life success is essentially fulfilling the utmost goal of one's life, which only the Creator of every life will determines A person could have attained material relevance and still failed from an eternal perspective. Real success can only be appraised when each person faces God, the Maker and Judge to give account of life. At that point, it will be obvious that material success while compromising on God's standards is not success.

Furthermore, even on earth, there are consequences faced when people attain material results by violating the absolute standards of character. Of course, it is quite true that some of those consequences may never happen in the lifetime of those who caused them. However, legacy always pays the nemesis for material success at the detriment of God's standards. The world today is facing the consequences of the past 'successes' of people who compromised the ethics of character.

Corruption, failed families, inadequate resources, global pollution, suicide, recession and economic hardship, fraudulence and a lot more problems today are because some people bent the rules some times back to attain some seeming success. The truth about success is that it can only be measured trans-generationally and eternally. Any success attained that put future generations in jeopardy is failure. A person who lived and acquired much but future generations later looked back and cursed his memory actually failed. It is true that success without a successor is failure and it is also true that success at the expense of future generations is failure. A father is who acquired material success but became the reason his children and future generations will bear an evil name failed.

Therefore, we can only truly know whether you succeeded or not we look at the world, your family, your children and your legacy,

generations after you are gone. Also if we can peep into your eternal fate after you are gone, we will know whether you succeeded or not. Let none damage character because we seek material success, there is nothing action in life without consequence.

## Succeed Intentionally

Success demands your pursuit while failure merely requires your permission. In order words, success will not happen to you unless you deliberately go after it while failure will happen to you even if you do not pursue it. Therefore, one can fail by mistake but one cannot succeed by mistake.

Have you ever given it a thought that every plant worthwhile needs to be planted and cultivated while weeds grow easily on their own? Similarly, a garden of flower only comes out perfect when carefully tended and nurtured by someone. However, when left to itself, it becomes overgrown with thorns and weeds. Hence, nothing left to chance ever comes out well. You must live intentionally; do not leave your life to chance. If you leave things to chance, they stand every chance of going wrong.

Similarly, character development and building the right attributes and attitudes for success will never happen by chance. You need to work contentiously at it. It takes consistent discipline, regimented routines and constant practices to develop great traits and a winning lifestyle. While bad habits and poor practices that lead to mediocrity and failure seem to come more naturally, the attitudes that make for success need to be developed. Self-indulgence is the natural inclination of most humans while self-mastery takes effort. Self-mastery is the seed for a harvest of quality character. Character is one major seed for a harvest of success.

There are lots of laws that govern success – the fulfillment of your God-given purpose in life. However, your character is a vital force. To be a true success, you must not merely judge your character by your actions but even your motives, thoughts and intentions. When you are really ready for the high prize of successful fulfillment of life and purpose, you will be more stringent on adhering to character standards by not merely paying attention to your actions and your outward life but your inner life as well. I know you have not changed figures and done the deal that wrecked your financial reputation and credibility but what about the tendency towards greed and dishonesty in your heart? If that is still there, don't celebrate yet, you need to work on it. You might not have run off with another affair and failed your family, but the yet to be outwardly expressed inner struggles with lusts and the weaknesses that make you 'want to' are equally dangerous to you family success. In the journey of success, you must be so meticulous that you pay attention not just to actions but even tendencies. As you grow in knowledge, principles, practices and understanding, also grow in character. You shall succeed!

## Some Success Character Traits

As we conclude on this chapter on the Unlimited Wisdom of Character in Success, we want to identify some character traits and attributes that need to be deliberately imbibed for maximal living. Note that these may not come naturally to you, you need to work at them.

**Honesty/Integrity:** Integrity is the core character quality. It is a basic measure of character. When you want to know a person of character, give an integrity test. Integrity and honesty denote that a person's word is consistent with his/her action. Integrity transcends saying the truth, it is living truthfully. If honesty is absent, there is a major character flaw.

**Discipline:** Discipline is the ability to do what one ought to do even when one does not feel like doing it. Discipline is a measure strength of character. Indiscipline is self-sabotage; it is handing over the rudder of one's life-ship to convenience. If you allow the winds to drift a ship, it will surely take it where the wind is headed and not necessarily where the ship wants to go. Indiscipline takes you somewhere but never where actually you wanted to go.

**Hard-work/Diligence:** Diligence is continual self-exertion in putting the mental and physical effort required to deliver an expected result. Diligence comes with the willingness to do things the way they should be done and the grit not to quit until the work is done. There is a subtle relationship between integrity and diligence. A good test of integrity is to check a person's work output. People of integrity generally pay the price of hard-work to meet the expected standard. The one without integrity probably has a plan to cover up and/or cut corners, so such a person lazily does a substandard work. There is also a direct relationship between diligence and discipline. Disciplined people continue in diligence even when they feel like quitting.

**Accountability:** This is the willingness to be examined and held answerable for one's actions. Accountable people have a sense of being responsible to a higher authority; human or divine, so they act with self-imposed restraint. Lawlessness is an offspring of lack of accountability. Externally imposed accountability is not a good measure of a sense of responsibility. When you see a person who is free, independent and yet accountable, you have met a one qualified for success.

**Chastity/Fidelity:** No matter the relativist culture in today's world, sexual chastity and fidelity still remains a core character parameter. Loose and multiple practices of sex is an advantage for baser animals whose major purpose for copulation is recreation and procreation. However, humanity is saddled with the responsibility of family, duties

of parenthood, the demands of marital trust, the complexities of emotional management, preservation of individual ethics, propagation of communal values, perpetuation of a responsible environment for future generations and the pursuit of spirituality. Thus, loose sexual practices are destructive to the character of humanity. Premarital, non-marital, out-of-wedlock sex, same-sex marriages and multiple sexual relationships all carry implications that necessarily will be eventually harmful to human perpetuation and society. This statement is not demean or profile any particular set of people. God loves all categories of people and as His children, we should love all. However, everyone must understand that the consequences of these practices will be destructive to personal and societal framework in the long-run. So, it is important to correct wrong acts because God frowns at the act though He loves the people.

**Boldness/Courage:** Boldness and courage are admirable virtues. The ability to take giant steps and dare great things are a display of strength of character. Boldness makes heroes out of every day people. Proactiveness, enterprise and the ability to take action is a character trait that must be intentionally cultivated for anyone to become anything worthwhile. Fear and timidity should be deemed as great a flaw in character as immorality and dishonesty.

**Dedication/Loyalty:** Loyalty is a character trait whose import is best seen when its opposite is demonstrated. We do not celebrate the virtue of loyalty in people so much but we detest the display of disloyalty. From simple betrayals to treason, lack of dedication to a course and people reveals a major character deficiency. If you are in with a course or a person, please be wholly in and stay in. Do not say you are in when your heart is out.

**Humility:** Humility is one of the strongest character traits. It is noteworthy that humility is not self-abasement but an intentional

ondescension to do the lowly and menial as long as God is glorified. Humility is necessarily accompanied by a healthy sense of self-esteem and self-confidence born out of accurate self-perception. A humble person is not struggling with a sense of inadequacy or inferiority complex. Humble people know who they are and are secure in themselves but still decide to reach down and do the needful no matter how lowly it is. It takes humility to start small and grow big. The proud person does not have the character to start small. Pride will prevent success and even if it attains it, it will eventually self-destroy it.

**Patience:** This is another very important character trait. Patience is the ability to wait for what you are working at to yield. It is a sense of delayed gratification applied to everything one does in life. Patient people are very powerful because they have the fortitude to stay at a task long enough to achieve success out of it. A person can be diligent but impatient. When diligence and patience meet, success is inevitable no matter how long the walk.

**Excellence:** Excellence is the highest level of performance. Excellence is applying the maximum sense of order to everything one does. Excellence is the minimum requirement for outstanding performance and success in today's world. Excellence, as a character trait, shows in everything one does: dressing, speech, work, home and environment. Excellence is an attitude.

**Prudence:** Wisdom, discretion and prudence in decision making is another character trait that is priceless. This is something that needs to be worked out and developed continually as long as one lives. Nobody can reach the end of wisdom, we all need to keep growing in wisdom, judgement, discernment and prudence.

**Love, Charity and Benevolence:** Love is one of the most misunderstood words in the world. Love is not an emotion; it is a decision.

**Love is selflessness, sacrifice and putting the best interest of the loved in consideration at all times, even ahead of one's. Love is the highest character value.**

**The list of character traits to develop for success is inexhaustible. Others include optimism, respect, compassion/empathy, punctuality etc. The truth is that when all is said and done, it is one's character that will eventually determine whether one will succeed or fail.**

## Exercise/Activity

1. Rate yourself on a scale of 1 to 5 on each of the character set listed in this chapter.
2. Mention three major character strengths you know you have and how you can further consolidate these strengths.
3. Mention three character weakness or flaws you have and how you can work on these to strengthen them. You may need to talk to someone candid and close to you to know your weaknesses.

**References**

1. Isa. 37: 31 NIV
2. Prov 22: 1 NLT
3. Rom 5: 2

# CHAPTER 5

# THE WISDOM OF RELATIONSHIPS AND NETWORKS

This WISDOM FOR LIVING Book will end by examining another important factor in attaining sustainable success. Which is the wisdom of building advantageous relationships and networks.

## The Power of Relationships

One most singular human factor in the pursuit of success and fulfillment are the relationships in one's life. The people around you in a large way determines how far you will go in life. To know where you are headed, look at where the people closest to you seems to be headed. If you need to change direction and results in life, the first step would be to change the relationships in your life.

In attaining success, a major area of investment is into advantageous relationships. The skills of managing relationships and creating advantageous affiliations and networks are great success asset.

## Types of Relationships

There are different types of relationships. All people are not the same to you and you must never relate to them as such. You must learn to define and demarcate different relationships for different areas of your life.

Different types of relationship include:

- Family Relationships
- Friendship Relationships
- Kingdom/Ministry Relationships
- Business and Financial Relationships
- Professional Relationships
- Romantic Relationships
- Marital Relationship
- Enmity relationships.

. . . Note that this is not an exclusive list.

It is important to limit one's interaction with people to the basis of the relationship that exist with them. If one is ever going to allow some people at a relationship type with one to cross to another type, it must be solely on the basis that they have passed the test for suitability for the new type of relationship. For example, a work colleague has a professional relationship with you and need to pass certain vital tests before you discuss your family issues with them. Otherwise, limit your relationships with them to professional issues.

A common relationship mistake people make is not to understand, define and limit interaction with people to the type of relationship that exists between them. This is the reason bosses sleep with their secretaries, work colleagues get into romantic relationships with each other, business partners share personal secrets which they eventually trade as weapons against each other when things go sour. It is amazing that some people are unaware of the the fact that because somebody has a common business interest with them does not mean the person deserves to be their confidant on personal matters. Lack of understanding of the limits and extents of the different types of relationship is the reason 'friends' defraud of money. Wisdom makes one understand that a friendship is different from a business

relationship. The fact that you are friends with someone does not mean they are suited to do business together with you. Family relationship is also different from work or business relationship. So, when you employ people solely because they are your cousins or siblings that need a job, you might be making a great mistake. The truth is that both you and the family member might be better off if you employ someone else and refer him/her to another employer. Also, friendship is different from a romantic and/or marital relationship. Therefore, because you have a friend of the opposite gender that you get along well with does not mean you should feel 'led' to marry them. There are many confusions and problems people get into because they do not understand how to correctly place and strictly manage people based on the types of relationships they belong.

Of course, it should be noted that a person can cross from a type of relationship to another. In fact, someone can occupy more than one type of relationship with you. However, this must be deliberately evaluated, assessed and consciously entered. You should allow people to cross from one type of relationship to another if you have discovered them suitable and consciously decided that they enter to that additional type of relationship. Therefore, for example, it is not impossible that work colleagues may eventually marry each other. However, this should be because they mutually discovered the desired quality of a suitable spouse in each other during the course of their work together, and not merely because the proximity of work influenced an emotional affiliation that they mistook that for a marital compatibility. Generally, roles, demands and personal attributes that make people effective as work partners are not necessarily be the ones that will be needed to complement each other as marriage partners.

## Three Directions of Relationships

Generally, there are three directions towards which we relate with people.

We are either relating with people above us, people at our level or people below us. It is humility to know that someone is above us in certain areas of life. It is equally not pride to know that someone is below us. However, whether someone is above, below or at the same level with us in life, we must relate with them in humility and accord them honour. According to 1 Peter 2:17, ***honor all people. love the brotherhood (the Christian family of believers). Fear God. Honor the king.*** We must treat all people with honour and respect whether they are above, below or at our level.

**The three directions of relationships are:**

**Up-Line/Vertical Relationship:** There are people who have been placed above us in the hierarchical structure of life. Examples are parents, bosses at work, mentors, teachers, pastors, superiors or seniors in a system. We are to accord honour to all people in our relations with them. However, when someone is above us, we owe them particular honour in deference to them. According to Rom. 1: 7, ***Render therefore to all their dues: tribute to whom tribute is due; custom to whom custom; fear to whom fear; honour to whom honour.*** There is the generic honour code we must apply in relating with all people. But, there are some specific others that when we honour them, we are giving them their due. 1 Tim 5:17 says, ***Let the elders that rule well be counted worthy of double honour, especially they who labour in the word and doctrine.*** This shows that elders (spiritual leaders and elderly people by age) are deserving of honour. This scripture extends to mean that anyone that is teaching, raising and building you in any regards, (academic, professionally and most especially in the Word of God) is deserving of a higher level of honour than you accord people generically. For this reason, teachers and lecturers are deserving of honour from their students and pastors, more especially, are worthy of honour from the people they lead.

**Horizontal/Side-Ways Relationship:** There are people at the same level with you in life. This includes friends, colleagues and partners.

The foundation principle for all relationships is honour. Therefore, we must honour people at the same level with us. When we have people at the same level, we should be committed to their progress and support them. Let it be evident to your friends, partners and colleagues that you are not in competition with them but are committed to their success and you expect them to be committed to yours. As much as lies in your power, make them know they are your team-mates and not opponents.

**Down-line/Vertical Relationship:** Everyone living a worthwhile life must have someone that they are raising. Down-lines include proteges, younger siblings, subordinates, juniors, children, employees etc. Remember, the foundational code for all relationships is honour. Therefore, the people under you equally deserve your honour. As a superior, the only authority you actually have over your down-lines is the honour they have for you. In other words, as a leader, the only right you have over people is their honour of you. If you lose that honour, you will see them walk away from you, then you will realise more than ever that their being under you was because of submission and honour out of volition.

Honour is actually reciprocal. The only way to get honour is to give it. Therefore, one must be most careful not to dishonour someone who honours one. A job employment relationship between a boss and an employee is usually the most non-volition of relationships. However, even at that, we have seen people walk away from a job because they felt dishonoured.

Another key to relating with subordinates is to show commitment to their progress. People below in relationship should have a value or service they are rendering to the superior or else, they are unnecessary in his/her life. Down-lines often miss the fact that their only access to a higher person is the service or value they are giving to him. A great person has so many people seeking his attention that he/she may have

no time for you except their is a role or value you are adding to him/her. The flip side is that the superior must be verbally and evidently interested and committed to their life progress of the subordinates as well. If downlines feel you are merely using them to achieve your end without consideration for their life, personal progress or life vision. They will only be with you as long as it is a means of survival for them and at that they can't wait to get out without looking back.

## The Honour Code

Honour involves recognising, appreciating and rewarding a person's worth and uniqueness. Honour should be according to all people irrespective of the direction of their relationship with you. This means whether superior, colleague or subordinate, the value of people must be discerned and appreciated. Dishonouring is a sin - When someone is playing a role or contributing a value and you think what they are doing is not really important. The driver is important, he is driving. It is not everyone that can drive safely. The gate-man is important, he is probably doing something you don't want to do. Your cleaner is important, if he is not there and you have to do the cleaner yourself, it will take time and effort from you. It is a heart of dishonour that makes one believe that he can dispose of anyone and replace them without any wink. Truly, there is no one that is indispensable or irreplaceable. However, it is not easy to find good people so honour every good person around you no matter their status or level.

It is important to note the fact that you are paying someone to do something does not mean you should not accord them honour for what they do. Honour involves showing people respect foremost because the are human beings like you, then secondly for the value they add. Honour has a tone, a demeanor, a countenance and attitude. It is important to speak respectfully to people. If you live in a culture where they are appellations and gestures for showing respect, use them for

**people irrespective of their social status.**
**Other important principles of honour include the law of appreciation and reward. Appreciation and reward should be done verbally, in actions and in giving. When dealing with superiors, honour involves going the extra mile and making sacrifices in service. You can claim to honour someone above you and serve them at convenience. Honour involves giving substance to the person you want to show honour to.**

## Seven Levels of General Relationships

There are different type of relationships and there are different levels of relationships. Another relationship mistake akin to relationship to with people on one type based on another type is relating with people on one level of relationship based on another level.
The following are levels of relationships:

**Stranger** - This is someone you do not really know, have not met before or do not have a relationship with. When you meet a stranger, you do not owe them access to your person or information. What you owe strangers is to show them God's love, be kind and give help to them. It is absolute foolishness to meet someone in a vehicle for the first time and you go off with information about your self, family, vision, work etc. People have met people in vehicles and because there a seeming sweet flow of conversation, they shared vital personal information. In fact, some there and then proposed marriage and believed they fell in love at first sight. Life information is not for a stranger level of relationship.

**Acquaintance** - This is someone you know but do not have a vital relationship with in a real sense. Neighbours, church members, school mates could be in this level. It is unwise to relate with acquaintances as if they are strangers. In addition to God's love that you owe all men, you must show courtesy, polite and kindness to acquaintances and give

them the honour of recognition. While it may be okay not to give strangers a ride in some parts of the world due to security reason, it is not right to see a neighbour, church member or an acquaintance who is stuck and drive pass as if you do not know them. However, an acquaintance does not deserve information about your person or secrets. The only difference between an acquaintance and a stranger is recognition. You really do not know them, you only recognise them, so be cautious.

**Fellow:** Fellows are people who are for what you are also for. They are with you because of a common course that join you both together. Fellows are vital parts of your success and are great assets to you so you must value and give your best to them. However, fellows are not loyal to you, they are loyal to the mutual course you all pursue. Therefore, you cannot commit your life to Fellows. Fellows are not to be your life confidants and personal secrets are not for them. There are not interested in you, they are interested in what you are interested in. When dealing with Fellows, you need to wisely guard your personal interest so that you will not eventually be at the losing end of life.

**Comrade:** These are people who are against what you are against. An old adage says, 'the enemy of my enemy is my friend.' This is quite far from the truth, the enemy of your enemy is actually a comrade.A comrade is also with you because of a common goal however, they are not loyal to you. If you join the other side of the common course, you become an enemy immediately. In fact, if the common enemy - which can be a system, an ideology, the government, a person or an evil, is defeated, you may be their next target. You do not owe comrades anything but inputs into the common course. You may need comrades to fight evil but be very careful of comrades; never put yourself into the hand of a comrade.

**Close Relationship/Friendship:** A friend is interested in you as a person

and give relational preference or deference to you above others. Anyone that relates with you the way he/she relates with every other person is not a friend. He could be a acquaintance, comrade or constituent. Friendship demands support and commitment to the person beyond the course, from both party. Many of the people people call friends are not friends, they fall into one or other of the categories above. When it comes to true friendships, every person has the emotional and heart bandwidth to accommodate just a few.

**Inner Circle:** They are people who you trust enough to let them know what is going on in your personal space and life. This level of relationship is earned through trust and loyalty. The higher the level of relationship, the greater the danger of having an unfit person in it. Among your friends and family, only few should be admitted into your life's inner circle based on proven love, loyalty and dependability over time. Your inner circle are your life's line of defense and are also the ones in the greatest position of advantage to destroy you if they decide to. Having a wrong person in your inner circle is not just a mistake, it is a disaster. A spouse is automatically in your inner circle, this is the reason choosing a wrong marital relationship is dangerous.

**Confidant:** This is the voice that you have trusted that you can open everything about yourself to and know that he/she will not take advantage of you, look down or you, but rather will cover, build and support you. Any level of relationship from friendship upward must be earned. A confidant level of relationship must be earned through utmost trust, loyalty and sacrifice. Your confidant should be mature (spiritually, emotional and mentally), must be someone who is sincerely interested in your well-being and progress and has proven it through sacrifices for you, a person you have proven love for you. This level of relationship is earned after you have tested and proven the person's maturity in handling crucial information, unfeigned love and security with your progress, genuine concern and sympathy in your

pains, and willingly to cover your faults and wrongs. There is no relationship type that automatically bestows this level of relationship on any one from you. Making someone your confidant should be your personal and willful choice. No one has the right to demand or think they have positional right (spiritual or secular) to be your confidant, this place in your life must be earned. If you married right, your spouse should be a confidant. However, not everyone has this right foundation in place.

## Jesus on the Levels of Relationship

Having established the principles guiding the different types and levels of relationships, it is important to give a scriptural background for them. So them these timeless truths would not be seen as fabrication opinions or the author's sentiments.

Jesus had people at all levels of relationships with him and He dealt different with them. There were always the crowd following Jesus, He loved them, healed them and ministered to them but never committed himself to them. They were mostly strangers and acquaintances.

John 2:23-25 says, ***now when He was in Jerusalem at the Passover, during the feast, many believed in His name when they saw the signs which He did. But Jesus did not commit Himself to them, because He knew all men, and had no need that anyone should testify of man, for He knew what was in man.***

Jesus also had people who were fellows and comrades. In Matt 2: 23 - 34, the Sadducee Council attacked Jesus with a tricky question on resurrection of the death. After Jesus silenced them with a profound answer, the Pharisees who had always been vocally opposed to Jesus, were happy and commended Him. This was because they were also on opposite grounds with the Sadducees on resurrection and Jesus' answer seems to favour their stand. However, they were not friends and Jesus never leaned towards them. They were comrades on this

particular occasion. A comrade is not for you, don't commit yourself to him/her.

Jesus referred to His disciples as his friends. They were always with Him and believed in Him. In John 15:14-15, ***He said, Ye are my friends, if ye do whatsoever I command you. Henceforth I call you not servants; for the servant knoweth not what his lord doeth: but I have called you friends; for all things that I have heard of my Father I have made known unto you.*** Friends are the ones that deserve access to your person, ways and information. However, even this is to different degrees.

On several occasions, Jesus would want to do or say something and would excuse all the other friends and allow only Peter, James and John access to this information (Matt 17:1, Mk 5: 37, Mk 14: 3) . This would look like absolutely partially unless one understand that there are information about you that is for the inner circle and not for every other friend. Peter, James and John were Jesus' inner circle when He walked the earth. Among all Jesus' friends, John believed he had a special place and called himself the Beloved and would ask for access to information that others were not privy to. If Jesus did not give everyone equal access to His person, you would not be wise to.

**General Relationship Tips:**

- You are to love everyone but you are not to trust everyone at every level of relationship. In relationship love is unconditional but trust is conditional. Agape love is to be given freely but trust is to be earned.
- Never give all people equal access to your person. Relate with people based on the level of relationship they are in with you. This is the wisdom for avoiding betrayals, hurts and pains in relating with people.
- The level of relationship you are with a person should be

determined by the perceived level of the person to the relationship with you and not your perceived level of relationship with the person. Therefore, be a master at letting people dictate where they stand with you.

- Relationships are investments. The level of investiture of yourself into a relationship is what determines what you get out of it. Be careful not to waste your investments. Every beneficial relationship will make demands on you. There is no point seeking a relationship, you are not willing to give the demands it takes. So, do not seek or accept a level of relationship that you are not yet ready to meet up with the demands or commitments of that level. Having a level of relationship with a person is not compulsory.

- Beneficial relationships must be intentionally pursued. There are people that are worth having in your life and will bring an advantage into your life. It is your responsibility to learn the laws that bring beneficial relationships to you. An example of such a law is shown in Prov. 18: 24; A man that hath friends must shew himself friendly: and there is a friend that sticketh closer than a brother .

- Never forget that the average cross-section/survey your close and frequent relationships gives a good representation of who you are. The overview of the people around you is also a good prediction of your future. You can change your future by changing your associations/relationships.

- Be henceforth be intentional in selecting and determining the relationships in and around your life.

- A key foundation in relationship is that you must maintain your self-esteem and self-worth in all relationships. Don't be need driven in any relationship irrespective of the direction. Rather, be value

addition driven.

- Don't Hang on to a relationship that is hurting, hurtful and non-beneficial. Life is too short for you to expend it on the wrong people. If a relationship is damaging and disadvantageous, it is not worth you life and time. In every person with a healthy sense of self-esteem in a relationship, there is the mind that is willing to release and let go if need be. Matt 10:39 says "***If you cling to your life, you will lose it; but if you give it up (for me), you will save it.*** This applied in relationships as well. Sometimes, the ability to let go freely is a sign of self-security nd self-esteem.

- There are no perfect people in life. In all relationships, you will need to accommodate people's inadequacies. While it is important to identify the weaknesses and strengths of people you are in relationship with, you should not major on their weaknesses. Support people to grow in their areas of weakness, remember you also have some weakness as well. Commend people's strength and encourage them. No one likes it when you always mention and dwell on their area of inadequacy.

**Exercise**

1. **Mention three advantageous relationships in your life in the following categories:**

**( i ) Up-line relationship**

**(ii) Horizontal relationship**

**(iii) Down-line relationship**

**2. Categorise the main people close to you at (i) home, (ii) work, (iii) church, (iv ) neighbourhood and (v) other places where you have vital relationships, according to what they really are based on the classification below. Be sincere and candid in your appraisal:**

**( i ) Acquaintance (ii) Fellows (iii) Comrades (iv) Friends (v) Inner Circle (vi) Confidant**

**3. Mention the two people each who bring the highest relational advantage into your life presently based on the following categories:**

**(i) Your most dominant source of favour (the person God uses to bless you the most)**

**( ii ) Your most trusted adviser/confidant (the person who really knows about you, protects information and tells you personal truth**

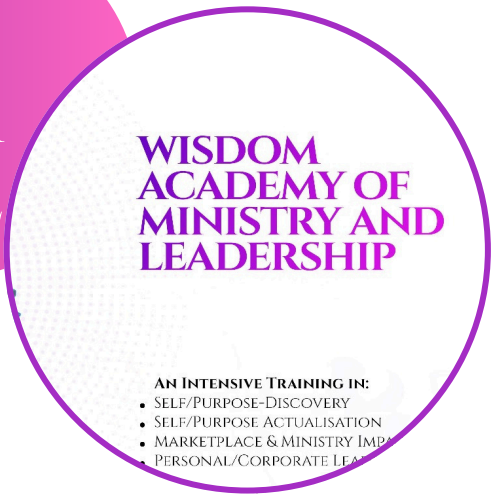
**(iii) Your most loyal servant/follower (the committed person who you can always count on to assign your task to get things done for you**

**(iv) Your most influential connection (the person you know and knows you and is of high standing in society**

**(v) Your most consistent teacher (the person whose instruction and voice has brought truth and clarity to you the most in life).**

The people listed above are among your most advantageous relationships, learn to value, honour and reward all the people you have listed. As far as you are concerned, they are not in the same category with everyone else in how far you can go for them.

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There are essential resources for actualising one's purpose and potential in life. Wisdom is principal among these essentials. Wisdom entails knowing the 'What', 'When', 'How', 'Where' and 'With Whom' of every action in life. Thus, Wisdom for Living is knowing the right thing(s) to do, the right time to do it, the right place/environment, the right approach/method, as well as the right relationships/associations to do it with in order to have a fulfilled life.

This book is a sequel to **The Life Assignment** which explains the 'What of Life' and **The Times and Seasons of Life** which examines the 'When of Life'. **Wisdom for Living** shows the 'How, Where and With Whom', thereby giving further insights into living a life of fulfillment and meaning.



## ABOUT THE AUTHOR

**Davids Oluwaseye Ayodele is a trainer, speaker and writer. He is graced with understanding and presenting complex issues with simplicity and clarity for practical application.**

**He is the founder of several initiatives both within the church and the workplace, such as The Wisdom Institute of Leadership and Ministry for training and equipping church leaders, ENABLED Multiconcept for business and professional leadership development and consultancy, as well as several other platforms for Bible-based teaching ministry. He has a bachelor's degree in chemical engineering and master's degree in engineering management from Ahmadu Bello University, Nigeria. He is married to Deborah OluwaNifemi and they are blessed with children.**